autonomous councils eventually engulfed the entire region, leading to violent protests, fights and displacements. Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Mizoram and Meghalaya are thinly populated states, with less than 10 million people in total, but STs make up over two-thirds of the population in each state. Further, over 90 per cent of legislative seats in the state governments are reserved for members of the STs. As a result, dominant tribes or groups have tried to enforce their power by calling for the physical relocation of less dominant groups from their areas, or have demanded exclusive protected enclaves. As a result, the Reangs were displaced in Mizoram, just as the Kukis, Paites and Nagas were displaced in Manipur. Throughout the Northeast, migrants from Nepal, Bangladesh and the rest of India added fuel to the simmering fires of ethnic division and found themselves in shelter camps after multiple rounds of displacement. In central India, the violence erupted from the Naxalite movement determined to overthrow the Indian state, rather than migrants or other tribes. The end result was similar as shelter camps emerged for villagers, mostly tribals, escaping the crossfires between the Naxals and the Indian security forces. In 2015, there were over 6,00,000 internally displaced people in India on account of armed conflict and communal violence, concentrated in central India and in the Northeast.[75]

An even more potent means of internal displacement arose in the form of development projects. The pursuit of modernity required dams and electricity, highways and railways, ports and plantations, cities and canals. All these activities required land for construction, cultivation and submergence. In India, one of the first sectors where land was acquired on a vast scale was for construction of the railways in the middle of the 19th century.[76] Inevitably, there were protests, court cases and arbitration leading to realignment of routes and changes in plans. Unlike Radcliffe’s lines, there was more flexibility and give and take in this process as the close attachment to homesteads and ancestral lands came in the way of neatly demarcated railway lines on maps. According to some tribal notions, forest clearance would anger their buried ancestors and lead to rains of fire balls